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1 TASTE TEST

For tourists, a visit to the Champagne region, such as this vineyard in Reims, is incomplete without a Champagne tasting session

2 THE MAGIC OF AGEING

A cellar in Épernay with Champagne bottles. Champagne undergoes a complex process, with the last step being a period of ageing

3 THE FINER DETAILS

Tiny, persistent bubbles are the hallmark of quality Champagne, bringing finesse, a silky mouthfeel, and a lingering effervescence

seurs rarely reach for a bottle of Moët.

A QUIET REVOLUTION

Champagne lovers are quietly stepping away from the big, mass-produced labels and embracing 'grower Champagnes'. These are bottles made by estates that grow their own grapes and produce a more artisanal, terroir-driven product in relatively small quantities. Instead of household names like Laurent-Perrier, Bollinger, or G.H. Mumm, the elite are stocking their cellars with Champagnes from producers like Frédéric Savart, Jacques Selosse, and Chartogne-Taillet. These brands may not have the same global recognition but are known for focussing on quality and craftsmanship, offering a more exclusive product.

In this sense, Champagne is undergoing a quiet revolution. While the big houses continue to dominate the market, there is a growing demand for Champagnes that prioritise quality over branding. It's a shift that echoes the sentiments of many winemakers who believe great Champagne should be treated with the same respect as fine wine.

Ultimately, Champagne's evolution from aristocratic luxury to pop culture shows its versatility. Whether toasting at a wedding or spraying bottles at a Formula 1 race, Champagne's appeal lies in its ability to straddle both tradition and trend. However, remember that Champagne is not just about the pop. It's about what's in the bottle. **BT**

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